KPPSC PMS European History • Paper I

Question 9 (2025 Q.8 / 2022 Q.7 / 2018 Q.8 / 2016 Q.8 / 2013 Q.8): > **"Explain the long-term causes of World War I (Militarism, Alliances, Imperialism, Nationalism). How did Bismarck's Alliance System evolve into two rigid armed camps, and how did the July Crisis act as the trigger?" > *(Total Marks: 20 • Word Count: ~650 words • Standard Exam Length)***

Introduction The outbreak of the First World War in August 1914 shattered a century of relative European stability, unleashing a four-year industrialized slaughter that obliterated four empires and transformed global civilization. The catastrophe was not an accidental tragedy born in a vacuum, but the explosive culmination of four structural developments summarized by the **'MAIN' framework: **Militarism**, the **Alliance System**, **Imperialism**, and **Nationalism**. While the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand at Sarajevo on June 28, 1914, acted as the spark, the continental powder keg had been methodically packed over four decades. The transformation of Otto von Bismarck's fluid, defensive alliance network into two armed, antagonistic camps—the **Triple Alliance** and the **Triple Entente**—subverted diplomatic flexibility into mechanistic entrapment, ensuring that a localized Balkan crisis inevitably detonated a global conflagration.**

From Bismarckian Equilibrium to Two Armed Camps (1871–1907) Following the unification of Germany in 1871, Bismarck recognized that the new Reich was a satiated, yet vulnerable, continental power. To secure Germany, Bismarck constructed an intricate alliance network based upon two core principles: keeping revanchist France diplomatically isolated, and preventing Austria-Hungary and Russia from clashing over the Balkans. Through the **Dual Alliance with Austria (1879), the **Triple Alliance with Italy (1882)**, and the secret **Reinsurance Treaty with Russia (1887)**, Bismarck juggled conflicting imperial interests with peerless virtuosity. However, the catastrophic rupture occurred in 1890 when the impetuous **Kaiser Wilhelm II** dismissed Bismarck and allowed the Reinsurance Treaty to lapse. Seeking an exit from isolation, republican France seized the opportunity to woo autocratic St. Petersburg, culminating in the **Franco-Russian Military Convention of 1894**. Germany now faced its ultimate strategic nightmare: an armed, two-front encirclement.**

Militarism, the Naval Race, and the British Diplomatic Revolution Simultaneously, the aggressive German pursuit of **Weltpolitik (World Policy) and the enactment of the **Tirpitz Naval Laws (1898–1900)** challenged Great Britain's undisputed naval mastery. By constructing a battle fleet designed to challenge the Royal Navy in the North Sea, Germany forced Britain to abandon its cherished policy of 'Splendid Isolation.' Britain revolutionized maritime technology with **HMS Dreadnought (1906)** and resolved its historical colonial conflicts with former rivals: signing the **Entente Cordiale with France (1904)** over Egypt and Morocco, and the **Anglo-Russian Convention (1907)** over Persia and Afghanistan. By 1907, Europe was irrevocably partitioned into two rigid armed camps: the Triple Alliance (Germany, Austria-Hungary, Italy) and the Triple Entente (Britain, France, Russia).**

Imperial Crises and the Balkan Powder Keg (1908–1913) Between 1905 and 1913, a succession of geopolitical crises heightened military tensions and tested the solidarity of both alliances. German attempts to fracture the Entente in the **First and Second Moroccan Crises (1905, 1911) boomeranged, driving Britain and France into joint military contingency planning. Concurrently, the collapse of Ottoman power in Europe transformed the **Balkans into the 'powder keg of Europe'**. The **Bosnian Crisis of 1908**, where Austria annexed Bosnia-Herzegovina with German backing, inflicted a humiliating diplomatic defeat upon Russia and enraged Serbian nationalism. Following the bloody **Balkan Wars (1912–1913)**, which doubled Serbian territory, an existential conflict loomed between a multi-ethnic Austro-Hungarian Empire terrified of dissolution and an aggressive Serbian kingdom aspiring to lead a South Slav union backed by St. Petersburg.**

The July Crisis: Mobilization Timetables and the Slide to War The catalyst arrived on **June 28, 1914, when the Serbian terrorist network 'Black Hand' assassinated the Austro-Hungarian heir, Archduke Franz Ferdinand, in Sarajevo. Determined to crush Serbia permanently, Austria secured a unconditional **'Blank Check'** from Kaiser Wilhelm II on July 5, guaranteeing full German military support. Austria issued an intentionally unacceptable ultimatum to Belgrade on July 23, declaring war on July 28. At this critical juncture, the rigid machinery of military mobilization overwhelmed diplomatic mediation. In nineteenth-century military doctrine, mobilization *meant* war: railway logistics and mobilization timetables were inflexible. Germany's war plan—the **Schlieffen Plan**—dictated that to survive a two-front war, Germany must rapidly knock out France by invading neutral Belgium before slowly mobilizing Russia could deploy. When Tsar Nicholas II ordered general mobilization to protect Serbia, Germany declared war on Russia and France, invading Belgium on August 3 and prompting Britain's immediate entry into the war.**

Conclusion In final analysis, the outbreak of the First World War was the product of systemic failure rather than single-handed design. As historian Christopher Clark demonstrated in *The Sleepwalkers*, the leaders of Europe walked into tragedy blind to the magnitude of the catastrophe they were unleashing. The alliance system, initially constructed to deter aggression through balance, had transformed into an escalatory transmission belt: an assassination in a remote Balkan city dragged six Great Powers and sixty million men into the slaughter. Bound by secret pledges, seduced by militaristic hubris, and paralyzed by rigid railway timetables, European statesmen proved incapable of halting the descent into the abyss. The 'Armed Peace' of Europe died in August 1914, burying four grand empires and ushering in the violent dawn of the modern twentieth century.
